

**FITNESSWISE**

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STORIES

THE POINT OF RECOVERY

With technology now widely used in fitness, it's **easier to identify** the appropriate recovery time and method to prevent injuries and improve performance.

Fitness + Recovery = Performance. This is the mantra to follow when embarking on a training journey. It's essential to train hard, train smart, and recover smart.

In recent years, there has been a growing emphasis on recovery rather than feeling guilty for missing a session. With technology now widely used in fitness, it's easier to identify the appropriate recovery time and method to prevent injuries and improve performance. Better recovery is directly proportional to better results.

With a wide range of recovery and planning protocols available today, choosing the most suitable one for your needs has become an art in itself. There are many proven strategies that promote faster recovery and greater gains. Here are some commonly used methods embraced by elite athletes and beginners alike.

Sauna/Steam

Living in a region with high heat and humidity can be challenging enough, and the idea of adding steam or sauna sessions might seem excessive. Nevertheless, these practices offer undeniable benefits.

Benefits

- ⚡ Improves cardiovascular and mitochondrial function.
- ⚡ Reduces muscle breakdown caused by workouts, contributing to a stronger physique.

⚡ Regular use improves Heart Rate Variability (HRV), a marker of nervous system fatigue, and decreases muscle soreness following intense training. This supports faster recovery for both your nervous system and muscles, helping maintain optimal efficiency.

How to use sauna/steam

⚡ Start with 5-10 minutes per session, ideally on a day that does not precede heavy training.

⚡ Gradually increase to 20-30 minutes at temperatures between 120-180° F, 2-3 times per week.

Just make sure to stay well-hydrated before and after sessions and pay attention to your body's signals to avoid overexertion.

Ice bath and cryotherapy

Shifting gears and flooring the accelerator to the opposite side of the spectrum, cryotherapy has become quite popular in recent years. Having encountered many studies both for and against it, we shall leave it to the individual athlete's comfort zone and needs.

Benefits

⚡ Many studies have shown that power output and work capacity improve significantly when post-workout cryotherapy sessions are performed regularly. Cryotherapy can also boost recovery.

How to use cryotherapy

The duration of cryotherapy depends on the method you choose. If you opt for a cryotherapy chamber,

you will only need around two minutes to get the job done.

Cryotherapy chambers are extremely cold, so you don't want to spend too much time in one, as you could end up with frostbite.

If you use the ice bath method, you can spend 10-15 minutes sitting in the bath to gain the benefits. Of course, this method is much cheaper and can be done from the comfort of your home. In a cryotherapy chamber, five minutes may seem like an eternity. Start with shorter durations and gradually add 30-60 seconds each time until you reach your target.

Foam rolling and massage

You have probably seen plenty of people using foam rollers and may even have noticed others using massage guns to limber up their muscles. While these tools might not directly improve your fitness, they do appear to have considerable benefits for recovery.

Research has shown that foam rolling can reduce the pain associated with delayed onset muscle soreness (DOMS). Similarly, massage has been found to improve range of motion, recovery, and DOMS when performed between training sessions. By incorporating massage, you can keep soreness at bay.

This process not only helps you feel better physically but also provides a mental boost, enabling you to train more effectively. Even if the benefits